

Build your own Canvas digest.

One email every morning with everything due and everything to read for the next seven days. You don't need to know how to code. You do need about ninety minutes.

What you'll end up with

An email that arrives at 7:00am, built from your own Canvas account and your own syllabi.

It groups the next seven days by date. Inside each day it separates what you have to hand in from what you have to have read, colour-coded so you can triage it before coffee. Work you've already submitted stays visible but greyed out, so "done" never looks like "missing."

~90 min

Start to first email

\$0

Runs on your own machine

0

Packages to install

Before you start

Check these three things first. The first one is the dealbreaker, and it takes thirty seconds.

- **Can you generate a Canvas access token?** Go to your Canvas settings, scroll to Approved Integrations, and look for a "+ New Access Token" button. Some universities have disabled this for students. If it's missing, nothing else here works.
- **Do you have a Gmail account with 2-Step Verification on?** You'll need it to generate an app password, which is what lets a script send mail. School Google accounts often block this, so a personal Gmail is safer.

- **Do you have your syllabi as PDFs?** All of them. This is where the readings-per-session data comes from, and Canvas genuinely does not have it.

You'll also need Python installed. Claude will walk you through it if you don't have it.

Never paste a token or password into a chat

Your Canvas token carries your full account permissions — submitting work as you, reading your grades, seeing classmates' data in group contexts. Claude cannot reach Canvas anyway; the script runs on your machine and reads the token from a local file. Credentials go in that file and nowhere else. If you paste one by accident, revoke it immediately and generate a new one.

The four stages

So you know the shape of it before you start. Everything begins with one message.

1 Send the prompt, syllabi attached · 2 min

Copy the prompt below into a new Claude conversation and attach every syllabus in that same message. Both together, one message. Claude reads the PDFs directly.

2 Claude interviews you, then builds your schedule · 25 min

Which courses, which sections, which operating system, what time you want the email. Sections matter more than you'd think: get one wrong and the meeting days are wrong all semester. Then every session and reading from your syllabi becomes one editable file.

3 You set up credentials and test · 30 min

Canvas token, Gmail app password, a config file on your machine. Then three checks: do the courses match, does a digest build, does an email arrive.

4 You schedule it, then tune it · 20 min

A daily task at 7:00am. Then a week of small corrections as you spot things filed in the wrong place. This part never fully ends, and that's fine.

The prompt

Copy this into a new Claude conversation. Attach your syllabi in the same message.

It carries the full architecture, the bugs worth avoiding, and instructions on how to teach you — one step at a time, waiting for you at each stage rather than dumping thirty commands at once.

Paste into a new Claude chat

Copy

I want to build an automated daily email digest that reads my university's Canvas account, so I stop missing readings and deadlines. I am attaching my course syllabi.

≡ THE PROBLEM ≡

Every professor organises Canvas differently. Some file readings under Assignments, some under Files, some post them as announcements. The authoritative schedule usually lives in a syllabus PDF that Canvas has never seen. Each system is sensible on its own. The cost lands on the student taking all of them at once, opening five tabs per course to answer one question: what do I actually need to do before tomorrow?

≡ WHAT I WANT ≡

One email each morning covering the next 7 days. Grouped by day. Inside each day, split into deliverables and class/readings. Colour-coded with a legend: blue for readings, red for deliverables, green for class and prep.

≡ INTERVIEW ME FIRST. DO NOT WRITE CODE UNTIL I HAVE ANSWERED. ≡

Courses and sections, ask these one at a time:

Attach every syllabus to this same message, before you send it. That is stage one, and there is nothing to do beforehand.

What to expect

It will not be right on the first run. Something will land in the wrong colour, a reading will show as a deliverable, a course will match the wrong syllabus. That's normal. Use `--audit` to see how everything got classified, and tell Claude what's

wrong.

Your syllabi will contradict themselves. An assignment described as due one date in the text and another in the summary table. Claude should flag these rather than silently choosing, and Canvas settles it either way.

Budget a week of small fixes. The first few mornings you'll spot things. After that it mostly runs itself until a token expires.

Built for 15.S23 AI Builder Space. MIT Sloan. Fall 2026. Adapt it freely.